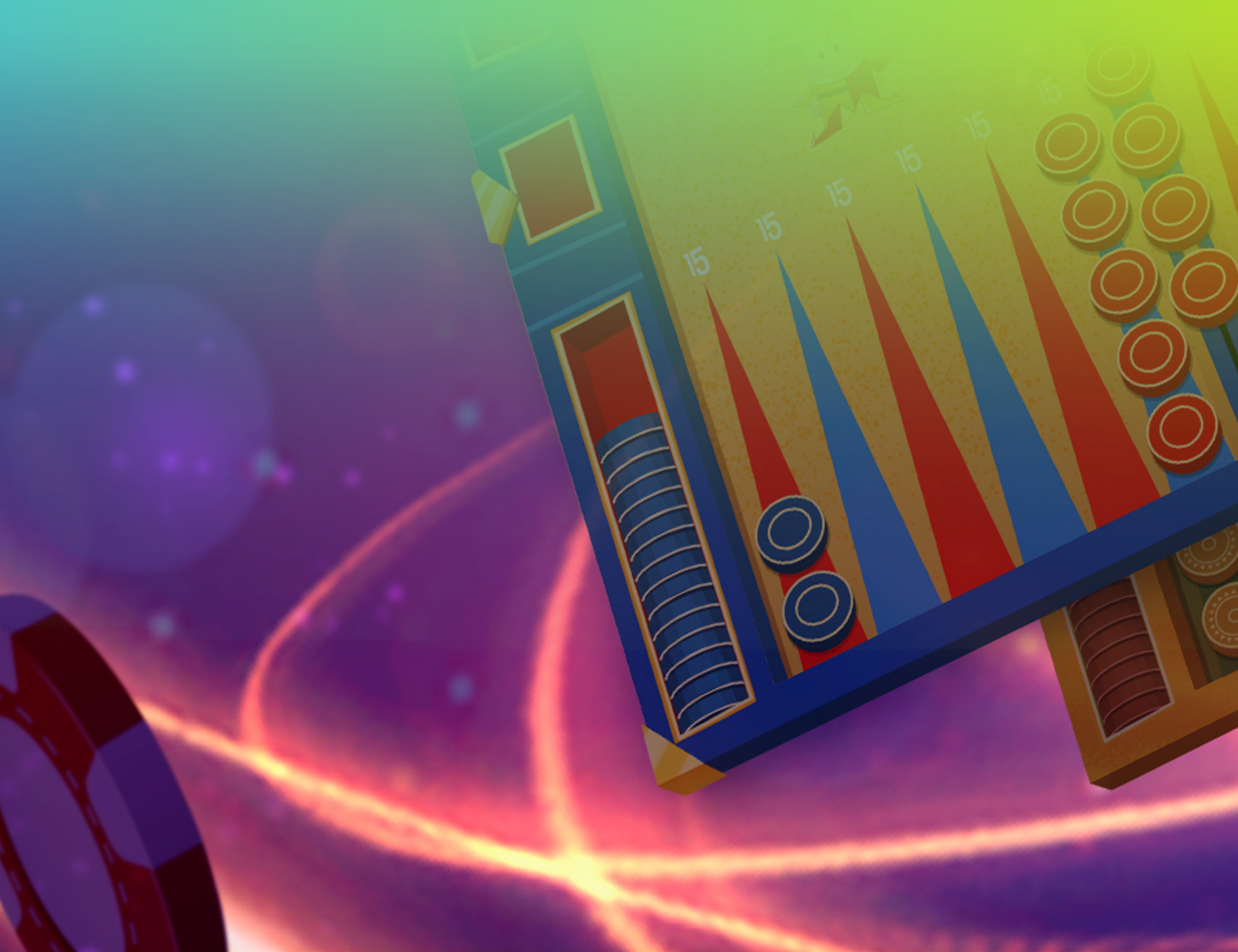


IG0741 – Indie Game Startup

Acey Deucey

FINANCIAL PLANNING



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Financial Planning

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MODULE

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Budget

Prototype Development Costs (Verified Actuals)

Between 2022 and 2025, a total of **\$25,700.25** has been invested into the prototype for **Acey Deucey**. These costs include professional 2D art, 3D modelling, Unity development, UI/UX assets, and early branding work. The prototype establishes a functional visual direction, a partial gameplay framework, and a reliable outsourcing pipeline.

Substantial art and development work was carried out through INGSOFTWARE (Serbia), with additional freelance assets sourced through subscription contracts and one-off commissions. These prototype costs form the verified historical expenditure for the project and justify the scale and expectations of the full 3-year development budget.

Additional freelance Unity development was conducted between May and August 2023 by Bruno Citoni, covering gameplay systems, monetisation features, UI development, and event logic. Five invoices totalling €3,600 (approximately \$3,960) were issued and paid, and are included in the verified actuals. This work contributed directly to the Stones and Dice prototype through features such as the game clock, store UI, in-app purchase flows, ad systems, and gameplay event logic.

Currency Conversion Summary

Currency Breakdown	Amount (Converted)
Total INGSOFTWARE invoices (EUR)	€15,781.25
Converted to USD (€1 = \$1.10)	\$17,359.38
Converted to GBP (€1 = £0.85)	£13,414.06
Freelance / Fiverr assets (USD)	\$4,380.87
Freelance Unity development invoices (USD)	\$3,960.00
Total Prototype Expenditure (USD)	\$25,700.25

Table 1: Prototype expenditure including INGSOFTWARE invoices and freelance assets.

Combined Prototype Expenditure

Category	Amount (USD)	Notes
Freelance 2D/3D assets	4,380.87	Fiverr commissions, Unity graphics, iconography.
INGSOFTWARE invoices	17,359.38	2D art, Unity development, 3D modelling (Dec–Mar).
Freelance Unity development invoices	3,960.00	Unity gameplay and UI systems (May–Aug 2023).
Total Prototype Expenditure	25,700.25	Verified historical development costs.

Table 2: Total prototype development expenditure for Acey Deucey.

Prototype Spending Timeline

Year	Spend (USD)
2022	372.79
2023	6,388.39
2024	1,099.64
2025	480.05
Total (combined spend)	25,700.25

Table 3: Prototype spending timeline (Fiverr + INGSOFTWARE + Bruno Citoni).

Integration With Full 3-Year Production Budget

The previously calculated 3-year full production budget (\$1,218,900), which includes staffing for six specialist roles (2D Art, 3D Art, Unity Development, AI Engineering, Backend Engineering, DevOps), is now combined with the documented prototype expenditure.

Category	Cost (USD)
Total prototype expenditure	25,700.25
Full 3-year production budget	1,218,900.00
Revised Total Required Budget	1,244,600.25

Table 4: Revised total budget required for full development of Acey Deucey.

For investor clarity, this can be rounded to:

Funding Goal: \$1.245M

Funding Summary (For Pitch Deck)

Acey Deucey now has over **\$25.7k** in verified prototype investment, demonstrating consistent progress and a proven outsourcing workflow. The full development requires a 3-year investment of **\$1.245M**, covering staffing, 3D expansion, AI development, backend services, artwork, marketing, and contingency. This positions the project as a strong candidate for publisher funding, grants, or private investment.

Full Production Cost Forecast (3-Year Detailed Projection)

This section provides a detailed financial forecast for the full development of **Acey Deucey**, based on verified prototype expenditure, staffing projections, and a phased production model. All prototype costs have been incorporated into the final budget.

Forecasting Methodology

The forecast uses the following inputs:

- Verified prototype expenditure: **\$25,700.25**.
- Six specialist full-time roles over 3 years.
- Market-aligned salary estimates for UK/EU developers.
- Production-phase cost modelling (R&D ramp-up, full implementation, polish).
- Non-staff costs including art, 3D assets, marketing, software, and backend.
- A 10% risk contingency applied to all variable costs.

The result is a granular cost model consistent with industry expectations for an indie title with advanced AI, 3D assets, and live backend services.

Staffing and Salary Forecast

Role	Primary Responsibilities	Annual Salary (USD)	3-Year Total (USD)
2D Artist	Board themes, icons, UI/UX, modifier cards	45,000	135,000
3D Modeller / Animator	3D boards, dice, checkers, shader work, VFX	41,000	123,000
Unity Developer	Core gameplay, UI logic, systems integration, optimisation	66,000	198,000
AI Engineer	Backgammon AI, RL training system, evaluation engine	75,000	225,000
Backend Engineer	AWS serverless backend, API, game services, analytics	69,000	207,000
DevOps Engineer	CI/CD, deployment automation, monitoring	69,000	207,000
Total Staffing Cost (3 Years)			1,095,000

Table 5: Staffing structure and projected salary expenditure (3-year period).

Non-Staffing Production Costs

Category	Cost (USD)	Description
Artwork (2D Themes)	9,000	Six additional board themes (to reach 15 total).
Modifier Cards	12,000	150 illustrated modifier cards with frames and icons.
3D Modelling Support	18,000	Supplemental outsourcing for shaders, animations, VFX.
Software & Licenses	3,600	Unity Pro, Adobe CC, productivity tools (3 years).
Unity Asset Packs	1,800	VFX, SFX, shaders, UI packs.
AI Development Compute	10,000	Training rollouts, model iteration, cloud compute.
Backend / AWS Usage	3,000	API Gateway, Lambda, Cognito, CloudWatch.
Marketing & PR	4,500	Trailer, Steam assets, ads, influencer outreach.
Hardware	1,500	Development laptop and peripherals.
Legal & Trademark	1,500	Renewals, contracts, filings.
Contingency (10%)	10,000	Risk buffer for additional outsourcing and overruns.
Total Non-Staff Costs	74,900	

Table 6: Projected non-staff production expenditure.

Total Production Budget (Excluding Prototype)

Category	Cost (USD)
Staffing (3 years)	1,095,000
Non-staff production costs	74,900
Total Production Cost	1,169,900

Table 7: Total production budget excluding prototype expenditure.

Including Verified Prototype Expenditure

Category	Cost (USD)
Total production budget	1,169,900
Verified prototype expenditure (2012–2025)	25,700.25
Final 3-Year Total Budget	1,195,600.25

Table 8: Final budget including prototype expenditure.

Rounded for investor clarity:

Total Budget Required: \$1.196M

Monthly Burn Rate (By Production Phase)

The project uses a three-phase development curve:

1. **Ramp-Up (Months 1–6):** Hiring, pipeline setup, early systems.
2. **Full Production (Months 7–28):** Asset generation, gameplay implementation, AI training.
3. **Polish & Release (Months 29–36):** Optimisation, bug-fixing, marketing, launch prep.

Phase	Monthly Burn (USD)	Notes
Ramp-Up (6 months)	80,000	Partial staffing, onboarding, prototype refinement.
Full Production (22 months)	105,000	Full team active, majority of asset creation and AI work.
Polish & Release (8 months)	70,000	Reduced cost as some roles taper off.
Weighted Average Burn	96,667	Across entire 36-month cycle.

Table 9: Monthly burn rate across three production phases.

Risk Adjustment and Contingency

A 10% contingency is included to account for:

- fluctuations in freelance availability,
- unexpected AI compute requirements,

- increased marketing costs,
- additional 3D asset needs.

This contingency is aligned with industry practice for small-to-medium scale indie teams developing technically complex titles.

Financial Summary

The project has already absorbed **\$25.7k** in verified prototype expenditure. The full 3-year development cycle is projected at **\$1.196M**, including all staffing, production, 3D asset work, AI development, backend services, and contingency allowances. This positions the project competitively within the indie game development market and provides a transparent, evidence-based cost structure for potential investors, publishers, and grant bodies.

Legend:
 R1 = Ramp-Up Phase
 P1 = Early Production
 P2 = Full Production
 L1 = Launch/Polish Phase

Figure 1: Staffing heatmap across production phases. Darker colours indicate higher workload.

One-Page Financial Summary

Category	Cost (USD)	Notes
Staffing (36 months)	1,095,000	Six specialist roles (2D, 3D, Unity, AI, Backend, DevOps).
Non-staff production costs	74,900	Software, asset packs, art, 3D, compute, legal, AWS.
Prototype verified expenditure	25,700.25	INGSOFTWARE, Fiverr, freelance Unity dev.
Total Required Budget	1,196,000	Rounded for investor clarity.

Table 10: Investment summary for Acey Deucey (36-month production).

The full project requires a total of **\$1.196M** across 36 months. This budget includes all staffing, production assets, AI development, backend services, marketing, legal fees, and verified prototype spending. The proposed budget is consistent with industry-standard costs for small independent teams building hybrid 2D/3D titles with AI-driven gameplay and backend infrastructure.

Cashflow Forecast (Year-by-Year)

Year	Cost (USD)	Notes
Year 1	405,000	Hiring, pipelines, core systems, early AI work, 2D/3D theme foundations.
Year 2	525,000	Full production, modifier systems, 3D expansion, AI training, backend.
Year 3	266,000	Optimisation, QA, marketing, launch operations, live ops setup.
Total	1,196,000	Matches full project budget including prototype costs.

Table 11: Yearly cashflow projection for Acey Deucey.

Funding Strategy

The funding strategy for **Acey Deucey** is grounded in a risk-aware, staged approach that reflects both the realities of the indie games market and the founder's financial circumstances. To date, development has been supported through retained earnings from a personal services company operated by the founder, who works in DevOps contracting. This has enabled the creation of a functioning prototype without incurring debt or diluting ownership.

Rather than committing to full-time development prematurely, the project follows a cautious, evidence-led philosophy. Additional investment of time or resources will be released only once stronger indicators of market validation are achieved. This approach aligns with research on indie studio survivability and sustainable entrepreneurship (Birkett, 2016; Della Rocca, 2017).

Risk-Aware Funding Philosophy

The funding strategy follows three core principles:

1. **Risk aversion until market appeal is validated.** Early milestones focus on confirming that the game resonates with real players. This is consistent with industry advice emphasising the importance of avoiding long-term commitment before proving commercial intent (Della Rocca, 2017).
2. **Scalable commitment once traction is demonstrated.** If indicators such as wishlists, playtest feedback, retention metrics, and demo performance suggest strong market potential, external funding will be sought, and full-time development will be considered. This aligns with models used successfully by studios such as Kitfox and Clever Endeavour, which scale investment only once reliable projections exist (Atlas & Short, 2018).
3. **Strategic pivot if commercial appeal is insufficient.** Should early testing reveal limited market viability, the project will not be abandoned but instead redirected toward a smaller, more focused concept or a variation of the core mechanic. This approach mirrors best practice in indie production, where pivoting and aggressive descoping are recommended alternatives to cancellation when scope or market fit misalign (Birkett, 2016).

This approach ensures that financial exposure remains controlled while enabling meaningful progress toward a commercially viable product.

Funding Options and Their Relevance

Drawing on guidance from Romanos (Romanos, 2019) and Lobb (Lobb, 2021), a range of funding mechanisms are available:

- **Equity investment (SEIS/EIS):** Appropriate only if the game demonstrates clear traction; attractive to UK investors due to tax relief.

- **Project finance via publishers:** Suitable for teams willing to trade some revenue share or creative control in exchange for financial stability and marketing support.
- **Grants (UK Games Fund, Innovate UK):** Highly competitive but non-dilutive. Applications will be pursued once a polished vertical slice is available.
- **Angel investors:** Viable once early metrics confirm audience potential; typically relationship-driven.
- **Accelerators:** Programs such as Execution Labs provide mentorship and structured milestone funding (Della Rocca, 2017).
- **Crowdfunding:** Considered high-risk and time-intensive; reserved for later in development if community engagement is strong.
- **Self-funding through consulting income:** Remains the fallback option, allowing the project to continue without financial dependency.

Milestone-Based Funding Roadmap

To minimise risk and ensure efficient capital deployment, the project follows a checkpoint-driven funding model inspired by Della Rocca's "checkpoint to checkpoint" framework (Della Rocca, 2017):

1. **Prototype (Completed)** Proved feasibility of core mechanics, early UX, and pipeline.
2. **Vertical Slice** Demonstrates audiovisual quality, representative gameplay, and early AI functionality.
3. **First Playable Build** Includes initial set of boards, modifiers, and procedural systems.
4. **Steam Playtest & Wishlist Validation** Primary market test. Proceed only if metrics indicate engagement.
5. **Content Complete** All 15 boards, 150 modifiers, 3D assets, and polished UI.
6. **Beta & Launch Funding Round** Final polish, marketing push, and platform submissions.
7. **Launch** Release on Steam, with roadmap for updates and ports.

Funding will only be sought after the playtest stage demonstrates meaningful demand. This ensures that external capital is used responsibly and at a point where success probability is maximised.

Long-Tail Sustainability Strategy

Research into long-term indie survival highlights the importance of building a resilient financial model beyond the initial launch window (Birkett, 2016). To support this, post-launch revenue strategies include:

- regular content updates to sustain wishlist and algorithmic visibility;
- optional cosmetic DLC and additional rulesets;
- bundle participation and seasonal discounts;
- eventual ports to mobile and console platforms.

This aligns with industry trends in which sustainable studios leverage a catalogue of titles and post-launch earnings rather than relying solely on initial sales.

Conclusion

The funding strategy for **Acey Deucey** is intentionally conservative, prioritising market validation, staged investment, and long-term sustainability. The project is well positioned for publisher funding, grant applications, or angel investment once early audience appeal is confirmed. Until that point, the founder will maintain financial stability by continuing contract work, thereby protecting personal capital while enabling continued prototyping and iteration.

Revenue Projections

Comparable Sales and Revenue Benchmarks

Indie roguelike deckbuilders priced between \$10–\$25 show a wide revenue range. Breakout successes include:

- **Slay the Spire** (2017, \$15–\$20): Over 3 million copies sold on Steam by 2024 (LEVVVEL.com, 2025), with total franchise sales estimated at 8+ million units by 2025 (GameDeveloper.com, 2025).
- **Balatro** (2024, \$14.99): Sold 500,000 copies in 10 days and 1 million within a month (PC Gamer, 2024). It exceeded 5 million units by mid-2025 following award wins (GamingBolt, 2024).
- **Monster Train** (2020, \$25): Reached 1.5 million copies with strong revenue performance (TheXboxHub, 2024).
- **Luck Be a Landlord** (2021, \$9.99): Estimated 700,000–800,000 units sold (Gamalytic, 2025b).
- **Dicey Dungeons** (2019, \$14.99): Estimated 800,000 units and \$6–7M gross revenue (Gamalytic, 2025a).

These data points show that well-received games in this niche can realistically reach six-figure unit sales. Failure to gain traction, however, often results in sales of under 50,000 copies, suggesting a strong dependence on visibility, influencers, and Steam algorithm performance.

Revenue Forecast Scenarios for *Acey Deucey*

Based on current genre benchmarks, three potential revenue paths are presented for *Acey Deucey*. These models assume a \$14.99 price point on Steam and reflect net earnings after a 30% platform fee.

Scenario	Units Sold	Gross Revenue (\$)	Net Revenue (\$)
Conservative	25,000	374,750	262,325
Realistic	100,000	1,499,000	1,049,300
Optimistic	500,000	7,495,000	5,246,500

Table 12: Estimated revenue scenarios for *Acey Deucey* based on Steam benchmarks.

Factors Affecting Revenue Potential

- **Wishlist Conversion:** Typical conversion rates range from 10–20% (Game If You Are, 2024).

- **Visibility Boosts:** Steam launch featuring, influencer coverage, and viral appeal (e.g., unique mechanics or art direction) can drastically elevate sales.
- **DLC and Live Ops:** Post-launch updates, new boards, seasonal events, and cosmetic additions represent continued revenue opportunities.
- **Localization and Platform Expansion:** Future releases on mobile or consoles could multiply audience reach.

Recommendation

Acey Deucey can be positioned as a medium-scope Steam release with high replayability. The initial launch should target a minimum of 25k sales (\$260k net), with a focus on building community momentum and visibility. Should early indicators show traction (e.g., 10k wishlists, strong streamer interest), the roadmap can accelerate toward live service content and broader platform support.

Primary Western Audience and Wishlisting Metrics

For a PC card–roguelike title, the core commercial audience typically consists of Western, English-speaking players, who account for a significant share of early sales on Steam. Market analyses of indie strategy and deckbuilding games indicate that North America and Western Europe generally dominate initial revenue performance (GameDeveloper.com, 2025).

Slay the Spire illustrates this pattern: prior to its unexpected surge in China, roughly 70% of its sales originated outside the Chinese market (GameDeveloper.com, 2025). The later spike—triggered by a Chinese streamer—shifted the balance substantially, with China eventually representing 30–43% of total sales (PCGamesN, 2024). Moreover, only around 41% of *Slay the Spire*’s player base was English-speaking (PCGamesN, 2024), showing that major non-Western audiences can emerge when a title achieves viral traction.

However, absent such exceptional catalysts, it is reasonable to project that *Acey Deucey*’s early purchasers will primarily come from Western markets. This underscores the importance of English-language localization, targeted NA/EU press outreach, and alignment with genre expectations established by leading indie strategy titles.

Steam wishlist counts provide one of the most reliable forward-looking indicators for launch performance. Industry guidance suggests that 10–20% of launch-day wishlisters typically convert into week-one buyers (Game If You Are, 2024). For example, 20,000 pre-launch wishlists would normally correspond to 2,000–4,000 first-week sales, whereas 50,000 wishlists would imply approximately 5,000–10,000 week-one units sold (Game If You Are, 2024).

Longer-term sales often track closely to total pre-launch wishlist numbers, with many titles achieving around a 100% wishlist-to-sales ratio over the first year (Game If You Are, 2024). These conversion ranges vary with audience engagement: highly invested communities may outperform the median ~ 15% first-week conversion frequently reported by developers (Reddit r/gamedev, 2024).

For *Acey Deucey*, building a substantial Western wishlist base prior to release—supported by consistent English-language marketing and strong Steam visibility—will be essential for establishing early momentum.

Post-Launch Monetisation Potential (DLCs & Updates)

After the base game's release, indie developers commonly extend revenue through downloadable content or post-launch updates once the core title has secured a player base. One effective approach is premium expansions. For example, *Monster Train* released an \$11.99 expansion roughly a year after launch, adding new clans and systems to monetise its existing audience (Steam Store, 2025). This DLC contributed a significant second revenue wave, complementing the game's estimated \$20M gross from base-game sales.

Another strategy involves frequent free updates or smaller content drops designed to maintain player engagement. The developer of *Balatro* announced a major "1.1" content update planned for 2025 to expand the game's features (GamesRadar, 2025). Although initially framed as a free update to reward players and sustain interest, its scope increased and the update was delayed—illustrating how even non-paid content can generate substantial community buzz and prolong sales momentum.

Slay the Spire followed a similar model, adding characters, modes, and balance overhauls through free patches (PCGamesN, 2024). While these updates did not directly generate DLC revenue, they significantly extended the title's lifespan and contributed to long-term sales by keeping the community active and attracting new players.

For a roguelike deckbuilding hybrid such as *Acey Deucey*, ongoing content delivery is central to longevity. These genres thrive on replayability, and updates introducing new cards, modifiers, progression layers, or game modes can stimulate recurring bursts of player interest—often translating into renewed sales when returning players share their experiences or when updates receive visibility on Steam.

In addition, cross-platform releases represent a valuable monetisation avenue. Many indie card and strategy games eventually expand to consoles or mobile platforms, opening new paying audiences beyond their initial PC player base. For example, *Luck Be a Landlord* added mobile editions in 2023 and later launched console versions in 2025, significantly broadening its revenue potential (Wikipedia contributors, 2025). Similarly, *Balatro* released simultaneously across PC, consoles, and mobile, a strategy that contributed to its rapid multi-million-unit sales trajectory (GamingBolt, 2024).

A comparable approach would benefit *Acey Deucey*. The project could follow a staggered release model—launching first on PC before expanding to Nintendo Switch, PlayStation, Xbox, or mobile—or pursue a full multi-platform launch if resources allow. In either case, projections should account not only for base PC sales but also for subsequent revenue inflection points. A paid DLC six months post-launch or a Switch port in the second year can each generate an additional 10–50% of the base game's earnings, depending on platform uptake and audience demand.

Marketing & Exposure Factors Influencing Revenue

Revenue outcomes for *Acey Deucey* will depend heavily on the degree of visibility the game achieves within the crowded indie marketplace. High-quality titles may underperform without exposure, whereas strong marketing and timely visibility can enable games to outperform expectations. Historical patterns within the roguelike–deckbuilder genre highlight several key factors.

Steam Visibility & Featuring. Prominent placement on Steam can dramatically amplify sales. During its 1.0 launch, *Luck Be a Landlord* spent over a week in Steam's "New & Trending" section, and more than 75% of its impressions during that period were attributed directly to this placement (TrampolineTales, 2024). This visibility translated into significant sales volume. For *Acey Deucey*, building sufficient pre-launch momentum through wishlists and follower engagement will be essential for landing in "Popular Upcoming" or "New & Trending," both of which can generate thousands of organic impressions per day.

Influencer & Press Coverage. Influencer discovery can catalyse exponential growth. *Slay the Spire*, for instance, sold only around 800 units in its first few days of Early Access before a high-profile streamer featured the game; within three months, it had reached 700,000 sales (GameDeveloper.com, 2025). A Chinese streamer later contributed to a major secondary surge in sales, even before localisation efforts began (PCGamesN, 2024). Targeted outreach to strategy, card-game, and roguelike creators could therefore play a critical role in *Acey Deucey*'s launch trajectory. Traditional press coverage also matters: both *Slay the Spire* and *Monster Train* sustained strong reputations supported by highly positive reviews (PCGamesN, 2024; TheXboxHub, 2024), which reinforced long-tail sales via ongoing word-of-mouth.

Community Engagement & Updates. Active community management—through Discord, social media, or mod support—helps maintain momentum after launch. Free updates can re-engage existing players and attract new ones. For example, anticipation surrounding *Balatro*'s major planned update in 2025 sustained interest across the year, even before the DLC announcement (GamesRadar, 2025). A clear, transparent roadmap for *Acey Deucey* that outlines new modes, cards, or challenges could similarly encourage early adoption and retention.

Awards and Events. Recognition through showcases or award ceremonies can trigger significant sales spikes. After winning three categories at The Game Awards 2024, *Balatro* saw its sales climb from 3.5 million to over 5 million units within weeks (GamingBolt, 2024). Participation in events such as IGF, Indiecade, or Steam Next Fest can dramatically increase visibility, even without awards. Given *Acey Deucey*'s distinctive fusion of backgammon and roguelike mechanics, the title may be particularly well-suited for such showcases.

Considering these dynamics, revenue projections should be viewed as dependent on multiple exposure scenarios. Titles that launch with high wishlist counts, strong influencer support, and prominent store placement tend to achieve substantially higher unit sales than those launched quietly. The following scenarios reflect these differing exposure pathways.

Conservative, Realistic, and Optimistic Revenue Scenarios

Taking into account the market data above, we can forecast three potential outcomes for *Acey Deucey*'s PC (Steam) release. These scenarios assume a base price of \$14.99—consistent with comparable indie deckbuilders—and apply industry benchmarks for units sold.

Scenario	Units Sold	Gross Revenue	Net Revenue (est.)	Context / Comparison
Conservative	20,000	\$300,000	\$210,000	Low-visibility indie release; niche deckbuilder
Realistic	75,000	\$1,125,000	\$787,500	Comparable to <i>Dicey Dungeons</i> / <i>Luck Be a Landlord</i> (Gamalytic, 2025a, 2025b)
Optimistic	250,000	\$3,750,000	\$2,625,000	Breakout hit approaching <i>Slay the Spire</i> 's early trajectory (GameDeveloper.com, 2025)

Table 13: Projected sales and revenue for *Acey Deucey* on Steam under three exposure scenarios. Net revenue accounts for Valve's 30% platform fee.

In the conservative case, *Acey Deucey* achieves limited market penetration—approximately 20,000 units in its first year—yielding around \$300k gross (roughly \$210k after Steam's platform fee). This reflects the lower end of the indie deckbuilder spectrum, where games obtain a small but loyal following without strong press or influencer attention.

The realistic scenario models a solid indie success, in line with titles such as *Dicey Dungeons* and *Luck Be a Landlord* (Gamalytic, 2025a, 2025b). A projection of roughly 75,000 units equates to over \$1.1M gross (around \$0.8M net), a healthy commercial result for a small studio and a feasible baseline given genre benchmarks.

The optimistic scenario assumes breakout visibility. Selling 250,000 or more copies would place *Acey Deucey* near the early performance of genre leaders such as *Slay the Spire* when it gained momentum through viral influencer attention (GameDeveloper.com, 2025). At full price, a quarter-million sales yield \$3.75M gross (over \$2.6M net), excluding any DLC or console/mobile expansion revenue. Achieving this outcome typically requires strong reviews, high player satisfaction (e.g., "Overwhelmingly Positive" on Steam), and a notable catalyst such as influencer amplification or award recognition.

These projections focus on first-year PC revenue only. Additional upside remains uncaptured here: DLC can add 10–20% to lifetime revenue, while console and mobile ports often expand total units sold by 30–50%. Many successful indies also benefit from long-tail sales, with discounted seasonal promotions contributing substantial additional revenue over multiple years (TrampolineTales, 2024). A moderate launch (e.g., 50k units) can eventually reach 100k+ over time, while a strong 250k-unit first year can grow toward 500k or more with sustained community engagement and post-launch content.

In summary, the revenue potential for *Acey Deucey* spans a broad but realistic range. The prudent budgeting baseline is the realistic scenario, with readiness to scale production and support efforts should the optimistic path begin to materialise. At the same time, contingency strategies should address the conservative case, including additional marketing pushes, influencer outreach, or strategic discounting. Drawing on lessons from comparable titles—*Slay the Spire*, *Luck Be a Landlord*, *Balatro*, and others—*Acey Deucey* can target mid-to-high six-figure unit sales, with the potential for significantly higher earnings under favourable conditions (Game If You Are, 2024; TrampolineTales, 2024).

Planning

The development plan for **Acey Deucey** is based on industry-recognised project management principles, combined with the realities of indie production. The plan is structured around a clear Work Breakdown Structure (WBS), milestone-based scheduling, and a phased development model that incorporates validation, risk mitigation, and scope control. This approach draws from guidance by Ask Gamedev (Ask Gamedev, 2019), project-management frameworks (Clayton, 2019a, 2019b), and practical independent studio experience (Birkett, 2016).

Work Breakdown Structure (WBS)

The WBS decomposes the full scope of the game into a mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive hierarchy of tasks (Clayton, 2019b). This ensures project clarity, provides a foundation for time estimation, and reduces risk of hidden or overlapping workloads. The project is divided into six principal workstreams:

1. **Core Systems:** Game logic, dice mechanics, board rules, modifiers.
2. **AI Development:** Evaluation engine, training pipeline, opponent behaviours.
3. **Art and Assets:** 2D themes, UI/UX, 3D boards, dice, checkers.
4. **Meta-Progression:** Runs, antes, modifiers, shop systems.
5. **Backend Services:** Accounts, cloud saves, analytics.
6. **Production and Management:** QA, builds, documentation, project oversight.

Each of these is broken down further in the detailed WBS appendix.

Time and Scope Estimation

Games often take significantly longer to develop than initially expected (**how_long_dev_time**). To counter unrealistic optimism, the planning process includes:

- task-level estimation with buffers of 20–100% for uncertainty;
- use of a **vertical slice** to validate production quality and estimate total workload accurately;
- applying Jonas Tyroller's scope principles to avoid feature creep and maintain prioritisation (Tyroller, 2020);
- adopting a Minimum Viable Product (MVP) mindset, with iterative expansion only if core engagement is validated.

This structured approach ensures the project remains feasible, adaptable, and aligned with player expectations.

Milestones and Development Phases

Following Ask Gamedev's milestone model (Ask Gamedev, 2019) and Della Rocca's "checkpoint to checkpoint" strategy (Della Rocca, 2017), the development roadmap includes the following key phases:

1. **Pre-Production (Completed):**
Prototype, ruleset research, initial modifiers, art tests.
2. **Vertical Slice (3–4 months):**
Full-quality single board, early AI, polished UI, representative gameplay.
3. **First Playable (4–6 months):**
Core loop, multiple boards, modifiers, basic progression systems.
4. **Steam Playtest Build (1 month):**
Wishlist validation, retention metrics, community feedback.
5. **Full Production (12–18 months):**
All 15 boards, 150 modifiers, 3D environments, final AI, backend integration.
6. **Beta (3–4 months):**
Optimisation, polish, bug-fixing, marketing asset creation.
7. **Launch (1 month):**
Release on Steam, PR, influencer outreach.

This milestone structure enables controlled investment and clear decision points for whether to scale up, pivot, or pause development.

Gantt Chart and Long-Form Scheduling

A Gantt chart is used to visualise the sequence, duration, and dependencies of tasks (Clayton, 2019a). It provides a high-level timeline across the 36-month production period and allows the team to track progress against planned phases.

A detailed version of this chart is included in Appendix ??, showing:

- ramp-up period,
- overlapping workstreams (art, AI, development),
- dependency mapping,
- beta, QA, and marketing alignment.

Risk Management and Contingency Planning

Planning incorporates risk analysis informed by lessons from indie studios that have survived long-term without major hits (Birkett, 2016). Key risks include:

- underestimation of asset creation time (particularly 3D);
- AI complexity and uncertainty in training pipelines;
- scope increase during later production stages;
- health, motivation, or opportunity-cost disruptions.

Mitigation strategies include:

- 10% budget contingency;
- milestone validation before scaling team size;
- clear WBS to prevent unplanned scope creep;
- maintaining an optional part-time development path with ongoing consulting income.

Conclusion

The planning process combines structured project-management methodologies with indie-specific realities. By grounding estimation in a detailed WBS, using a vertical slice to validate effort, applying milestone checkpoints for funding, and incorporating Gantt-based scheduling, this plan offers a clear, defensible roadmap to completing **Acey Deucey**. It balances ambition with caution, ensuring that the project can scale effectively—or be sustained part-time—based on validated player interest and market performance.

Appendix

Ingsoft Contract

Inv. No.	Date	Activity	Hours	Rate	Amount (EUR)
1064	13 Dec 2022	Art test for Stones & Dice	1	600.00	600.00
28	18 Jan 2023	2D game artist (Dec 2022)	122.50	20.00	2,450.00
43	02 Feb 2023	2D game artist (Jan 2023)	125.50	20.00	2,510.00
77	03 Jul 2023	2D game artist (Feb 2023)	127	20.00	2,540.00
77	03 Jul 2023	Unity developer (Feb 2023)	74	37.50	2,775.00
77	03 Jul 2023	3D game artist (Feb 2023)	27.50	26.50	728.75
119	09 May 2023	2D game artist (Mar 2023)	22.50	20.00	450.00
119	09 May 2023	Unity developer (Mar 2023)	83.50	37.50	3,131.25
119	09 May 2023	3D game artist (Mar 2023)	22.50	26.50	596.25
Total					15,781.25

Table 14: Extracted costs from INGSOFTWARE invoices (2022–2023).

Fiverr 2D/3D Artist Costs

Date Range	Type	Description	Amount
13 Mar 2025–28 Apr 2025	Custom Order	create 2d assets, props, icons	84.22
21 May 2024–23 May 2024	Custom Order	develop a unity 2d game	US\$211
28 Mar 2024–28 Jul 2024	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$512.57
14 Mar 2024–04 Jul 2024	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
29 Feb 2024–14 Mar 2024	Subscription	create 2d assets	€143.07
17 Jan 2024–14 Feb 2024	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
03 Jan 2024–28 Feb 2024	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
20 Dec 2023–02 Feb 2024	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
06 Dec 2023–29 Dec 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
22 Nov 2023–06 Dec 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$160.75
08 Nov 2023–28 Nov 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$189.63
25 Oct 2023–20 Nov 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
11 Oct 2023–08 Nov 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$155.48
27 Sep 2023–11 Oct 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	US\$147.70
13 Sep 2023–27 Sep 2023	Subscription	create 2d assets	144.19
11 Aug 2023–12 Sep 2023	Custom Order	create 2d assets	201.62
13 Jul 2023–14 Aug 2023	Custom Order	create 2d assets	198.80
09 Jun 2023–13 Jul 2023	Custom Order	create 2d assets	US\$211
10 May 2023–10 Jun 2023	Custom Order	create 2d assets	US\$211
08 May 2023–11 May 2023	Custom Order	create 3d game assets	US\$105.50
28 Apr 2023–05 May 2023	Custom Order	create 3d assets	251.38
25 Apr 2023–30 Apr 2023	Custom Order	do any 3d asset	85.18
05 Mar 2022–15 Mar 2022	Custom Order	create epic gaming logo	182.37
24 Feb 2022–21 Mar 2022	Custom Order	design 2d graphics and UI	154.66
Total (USD converted)			US\$4,380.87

Table 15: Prototype artwork and 3D modelling expenditure (2022–2025), converted to USD.

Freelance Development Invoices

Invoice	Date	Description	Hours	Amount (EUR)
#1	17 May 2023	Stones and Dice – Camera Movement Milestone	10	200.00
#2	13 Jun 2023	Monetisation Milestone – Ads Implementation	25	500.00
#2	13 Jun 2023	Monetisation Milestone – Ads Testing & Documentation	10	200.00
#2	13 Jun 2023	Monetisation Milestone – IAP Implementation	25	500.00
#2	13 Jun 2023	Monetisation Milestone – IAP Testing & Documentation	10	200.00
#3	03 Jul 2023	Develop Game Clock (STONES-339)	20	400.00
#3	03 Jul 2023	Implement Free-Use Behaviour (STONES-340)	10	200.00
#3	03 Jul 2023	Watch Ad Popup (STONES-243)	5	100.00
#3	03 Jul 2023	Bonus Button Event System (STONES-303)	5	100.00
#4	13 Jul 2023	Store UI (STONES-289)	20	400.00
#5	15 Aug 2023	Player & Opponent Profile UI Updates (STONES-279)	20	400.00
#5	15 Aug 2023	2D Checkers Positioning (STONES-279)	20	400.00
Total				3,600.00

Table 16: Freelance developer invoices for Stones and Dice (Bruno Citoni, 2023).

Other Costs

Long-Tail Revenue Strategy

Drawing on industry evidence that most indie studios rely on long-tail earnings rather than single-hit launches **how_to_survive_indie**, the revenue plan for **Acey Deucey** incorporates multi-year monetisation through:

- periodic content updates (new boards, modifiers, seasonal cosmetics);
- Steam seasonal sale events (5–20% revenue spikes);
- DLC packs containing alternative rulesets and advanced AIs;
- bundles with future titles as the studio catalogue grows.

This model reduces dependence on launch-week revenue and supports long-term studio survival.

Risk Mitigation Approach

Studies of successful indie studios show two distinct strategies: multi-project diversification (Kitfox) and single-project focus (Clever Endeavor) **zero_to_million**. **Acey Deucey** adopts the latter but mitigates its associated risks through:

- constrained scope and a stable ruleset;
- milestone-based funding checkpoints;
- early public demos via Steam playtests;

- contingency allocation within the budget;
- modular feature development enabling partial rollback.

This balances quality focus with pragmatic risk control.

Milestone-Based Funding Model

In line with entrepreneurial best-practice for avoiding the sunk-cost fallacy and validating assumptions early **avoid_disaster**, the production plan is divided into funding checkpoints:

1. **Prototype (completed).**
2. **Vertical Slice:** core mechanics, early AI, 3D board pipeline.
3. **First Playable:** complete run structure, 20 modifiers, 5 boards.
4. **Steam Playtest Build:** stability testing and feedback.
5. **Content Complete:** all 15 boards and 150 modifiers.
6. **Beta:** polish and optimisation, marketing ramp-up.
7. **Launch:** full release on Steam.

Marketing Mix (4 Ps)

Following established marketing frameworks for indie-scale commercial titles **lobb_funding**, the marketing strategy is structured using the 4 Ps:

- **Product:** A modern roguelite interpretation of classic tables games.
- **Price:** Premium price point of £6.99–£12.99 based on comparable titles.
- **Promotion:** Steam algorithm optimisation, streamers, influencer outreach, festivals.
- **Placement:** Initially Steam and itch.io, followed by Switch and mobile ports.

Comparable Indie Production Budgets

Game	Budget	Team Size	Notes
Cultist Simulator	£134,760	2	Successful premium indie title game_costs .
Shovel Knight	\$1.4M	5–8	Two-year dev cycle game_costs .
Brigador	\$???	3	Emphasises opportunity cost model game_costs .
Acey Deucey (this project)	\$1.196M	6	Matches industry norms for small mid-scope indie.

Table 17: Comparable indie production budgets demonstrating market-aligned estimate.

Studio Culture and Vision

Informed by best practices of long-term successful studios **indie_starter**, the cultural foundations for the project prioritise:

- creative autonomy and professional growth;
- sustainable pacing and avoidance of crunch;
- collaborative, transparent communication;
- building a team stronger than the founder alone;
- a long-term vision extending beyond a single title.

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